

The Human Premium

WORKBOOK

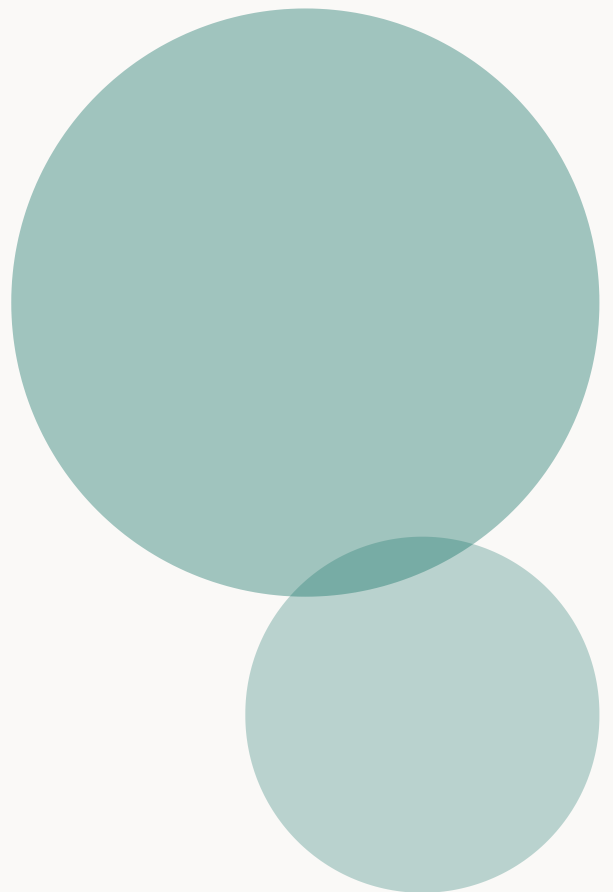
When everyone has the same tools

Three moves, three commitments, and seven questions to answer honestly.

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Two ways to read this

If you are already building something, apply every move and every question to the thing in flight. If you have not started, apply them to the idea you are most tempted to build. The moves are the same. Only the tense changes.

The idea

In 2026, anyone can build almost anything. What took a team a quarter can start with a prompt and an afternoon. AI removed much of the cost of building. It did not remove the cost of being wrong. So the ability to build is no longer the thing that sets you apart, and it is now easy to build the wrong thing beautifully.

AI made building cheap; it made understanding what people really need more valuable than ever. That is the human premium, and it is not one heroic decision. It is a way of building: **understand the problem, build with people, learn from behavior.**

Three moves

01 Understand the problem

Understand the problem before defining the solution.

Before you fall in love with an idea, spend time with the person who has the problem. Not a persona generated by AI. Not the customer described in your deck. An actual person.

Three questions to ask them:

- Who has this problem?
- What do they do today?
- What would need to change for this to matter?

Do this Monday. Take the idea you are most tempted to build, or the thing you are already building, and find the actual person who would use it. Ask those three questions in that order. Do not send a survey and do not brief someone else to do it.

02 Build with people

Design with people, not merely for them.

Do not disappear for three months and return with a finished solution. Involve people before the requirements are fixed.

- Put something incomplete in their hands early.
- Let their behavior change the direction.
- Human-centered does not mean slower. It means learning before the solution becomes expensive.

Do this Monday.

Already building: find the thing you are holding back until it is ready, and show it this week in its incomplete state, to someone who would actually use it, while the requirements can still move.

Not started: decide what the smallest incomplete version is that someone could react to, and put a date on when they will see it. Make that date earlier than the date you would feel ready.

03 Learn from behavior

Watch what people do, not only what they say.

Shipping is an output. Changed behavior is an outcome. A working product proves that you can build; changed behavior proves that it matters.

What you built	What changed for someone
A product was launched	Someone completes the work faster
A feature was shipped	Someone stops using the old workaround

Do this Monday. Write down the behavior you expect to change, before you build. Faster work, a better decision, or an abandoned workaround. Do this now, while it is still a prediction and not a justification, so that delivery cannot quietly become the definition of success.

Already shipped something? Do the same test backwards. Name the behavior that changed because of the last thing you shipped. If you cannot name one, you shipped something, but you did not create change.

Your three Monday commitments

One per move. Answer with a name, a date, or a behavior — not an intention.

01 The actual person I will speak to, and when:

02 What I will show while it is still incomplete, to whom, and the date they will see it:

03 The behavior I expect to change:

The 48-hour challenge

Most people leave events inspired but unchanged. From the end of the talk you have 48 hours, which means you have until Monday. Do not use the conversation to validate what you already believe. Let it change something.

1. One idea I am tempted to build:

2. One person who would actually use it:

3. One assumption I changed because of what I learned:

Where do you actually stand?

Pick one thing: the initiative you are running, or the idea you have not started yet. Answer each question with a specific name, a specific date, or a specific behavior. **“In principle, yes” counts as no.**

- 1 Can you name the actual person who has the problem, or are you working from a persona, a segment, or a description in a deck?

- 2 Do you know what that person does today, including the workaround they are using right now?

- 3 Has anyone outside the team touched something incomplete, and can the direction still change based on what they do?

- 4 How many days from starting to the first person outside the team using it? Count from the day you begin, not from the day you feel ready.

- 5 Can you name the specific behavior that should change if this matters, or would delivery itself be reported as the success?

- 6 Name the most recent assumption you changed because of what a user actually did. Not one that was confirmed.

- 7 Across everything in flight or queued up, how many started from a problem someone described, and how many started from an idea someone had?

Reading your answers

The questions you answered with a name, a date, or a behavior are where you are already earning the human premium. The ones where you reached for a process, a plan, or a persona are where you are building on assumptions.

Assumptions are cheap to produce now, which is exactly the problem.

If you could not name an assumption you changed at question six, that is your 48-hour challenge.

One line to keep

AI can help you build almost anything. Only people can tell you what is worth building.
Build with them.

**Technology creates possibilities.
People create change.**

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